

The Painter Laureate's A Philosopher as Well

By WILLIAM RAIDY

Maurice Sievan, "the painter laureate of suburbia," is as much a philosopher as he is an artist.

Sievan, an art instructor at Queens College, Flushing, reflects his feelings concerning life, its uncertainty and its beauty, in his canvases. These paintings, he points out, are not always cheerful, but neither is life.

"When people come and look at my art," said Sievan, a robust man with sharp, intense eyes, "I often recall what Bertrand Russell said once when I was studying under him: 'If you don't have the strength of mind to think of these things, please go home...'"

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YEARS BEFORE Sputniks encircled the globe, Sievan was creating canvases depicting man clutching the Earth-globe on a mysterious journey through the universe.

Sievan hates to be categorized in his art. He adds he is not a realist; he is not an abstractionist.

"I do so many things ... in so many different ways," said Sievan, showing us a group of paintings done in the past three decades as we talked of life and art in his attic-studio in his Jamaica Estates North home.

"The artist is not always understood in his time," Sievan continued. "Van Gogh, for example, was detested ... and worse, misunderstood ... by his contemporaries."

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THE PAINTER told us he was an artist before he even knew there was such a thing.

"I was born in Russia ... under the czars," the artist, sitting beside one of his colorful landscapes, began. "My father was a farmer, our nearest neighbors, two miles away."

"We had no pictures in the house and not one pencil," he continued. "The only drawing I saw as a young boy was an engraving in the family Bible. And still I began to draw, using my father's only pen. Soon I began to draw the trees and the things around

me, gaining much pleasure from my work."

"One day one of our landlords, a nobleman, came to the house. 'Where is the man who has done this work,' he asked my father. When he was told the drawings were done by a four-year-old, the old landowner said: 'He is an artist ... an artist.'"

"It was the first time I had ever heard the word!"

ART HAS BEEN a way of life for Sievan ever since. Some of the great museums of the world, as well as the leading galleries, have shown the artist's works. He holds a number of top awards for his paintings, including the Newhouse Memorial Award in 1949.

Sievan, who lives at 76-47 171st St., has been called "the painter laureate of suburbia" because he has found great beauty in the streets, the gas stations, the gardens of Long Island ... and recorded that beauty on his canvases.

A Long Island Railroad underpass, the Queens Botanical Gardens, an inlet at Peconic Bay, a group of homes clustered together in Hollis, all have provided artistic inspiration for Sievan.

The artist sees the beauty ... not the possible monotony ... of these familiar scenes.

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THE SIEVAN HOME, incidentally, is one great art gallery, crowded with the artist's paintings.

"Come to my cellar gallery," said Sievan as he led us down the stairway. "And you will see a retrospective show of my art."

The room, in beauty and arrangement, could rival most of Manhattan's plush 57th St. galleries.

"This is the way I wish everyone could see my paintings ... not always in the commercial galleries," he said.

The artist, Sievan contends, should be seen like a bird ... in his native habitat.

"Going to a gallery is like looking at a bird in a cage instead of a tree," he said. "Here I am in my own world."

The world was one of beauty indeed.